



Perceived Vice and Unengaging Edification

Game Analyses of Two Christian Digital Games.

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degree of M.Sc. in Digital Games.*



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To John Doe

Some more descriptive text.

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Abstract

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NPC Non-Playable Character	22
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Introduction

There are many opinions that one could hold towards Christian digital games. Those who played them as children, such as Bri (2007) and Prairiedog (2007), might hold fond memories of such games and argue that they are still great. Others, as Gonzalez (2014) notes, might view them as a “convenient cluster for derision” (p. 8). However, there is another considerable group that does not necessarily ridicule such games, but still critiques their instructive elements.

Among these individuals we could count several of the interviewees in the study by Schut (2013) who consider them to be “preachy” (p. 139). Others, like Hartgrove (2022), might complain that Christian digital games often shoehorn educational elements while also lacking quality. Meanwhile, others might opine that Christian games convey their underlying themes (i.e., their message) too unsubtly (Games and Groceries Podcast, 2020) or forcefully Monkastery (2018, 6:13–9:19). Yet others might argue that the educational focus in these games directly limits the joy they can provide (Moon Channel, 2023, 34:40).

1.1 | Motivation

Meanwhile, existing research either avoids examining engagement in such games entirely (Gonzalez, 2014), mentions these negative experiences without attempting to explain why they occur (Schut, 2013), or proposes general reasons for the unpopularity of Christian digital games (Bernauer, 2012; Schut, 2026). Most suggestions provided in the third category are outside developers’ control. Thus, they are of little use to them.

At the same time, similar complaints persist in more recent titles. For instance, while playing a demo build of the upcoming Christian digital game *One of 500* (Lightword Productions GmbH, n.d.), Monkastery (2024, 23:28) encounters a part of the game where the player must read through a chapter from the book of Isaiah and answer some multiple-

choice questions afterwards. Monkastery reacted by expressing his disappointment at the inclusion.

Moreover, there are also other cases beyond Christian digital games where individuals criticise the game for its heavy-handedness. As an example, see the review for *Detroit: Become Human* (Cage, 2018) by O'Brien (2018).

1.2 | Aims and Objectives

The goal of this study is to understand why certain players might view certain elements in Christian digital games negatively. These explanations should be clear so that developers can better recognise how they can mitigate or avoid such issues entirely. Furthermore, the causes should be actionable, meaning they can be managed during the game development cycle.

1.3 | My Approach

In this analysis, I investigate the formal elements of Christian digital games to understand how they might be giving rise to such opinions. Based on the perspectives of King (2017), Repp (2012), and the Player Involvement model by Calleja (2011), I propose two mutually-inclusive causes. First, I suggest that digital games can be deemed didactic because they contain elements likely to lead players to believe that the developers are intellectually dishonest. Second, I suggest that the method used to deliver instruction to players can limit the affordances for player engagement, leading players to regard the included instruction negatively.

Later, I apply this framework to two Christian digital games, both to verify and demonstrate its effectiveness on different examples. I begin by examining *Alum* (Orsie, 2015), a Christian digital game whose narrative players have panned as heavy-handed for its dogmatic and prejudiced undercurrents. Afterwards, I consider *Captain Bible in Dome of Darkness* (Engelbrite, 1994), an edutainment game which players have criticised for its didacticism (Moon Channel, 2023) and praised for its unique gameplay, which is tightly linked to the game's educational aims (Censorious Idler, 2018).

1.4 | Scope

Christian digital games are not the only type of game criticised for their aspirations to edify. Case in point, Johnson (2018) opines about a Christian tabletop role-playing game, calling it “preachy” (What I did not like section, para. 4). Of course, Christian analogue games, and perhaps Christian analogue-digital hybrids if they even exist, are also worth exploring. Nevertheless, to keep this investigation within a manageable scope, I will focus primarily on cases surrounding digital games.

The examples I consider in this investigation concern instruction in both the pedagogical sense (e.g., in edutainment) and the thematic sense, often present in games with a narrative focus (i.e., games with a message). Nevertheless, I believe that the accounts I explore in this research could also provide insight into elements that attempt to indicate to the player how to engage with the game, such as environmental markers. Nevertheless, I will evaluate instructional or informational content only in terms of its effect on the player’s perception and engagement. I will not consider other aspects, such as the effectiveness of the teaching methods in *Captain Bible in Dome of Darkness* (Engelbrite, 1994).

Lastly, (Calleja, 2011, p. 7) notes that generally game research tends to prioritise one of the following qualities: formal elements, player experience, or the groups and cultures surrounding them. Although I focus on formal elements as a potential cause of negative opinions towards informative elements, ultimately the former are also a product of the player’s own subjectivity. Hence, my study will concentrate primarily on the second quality.

1.5 | Document Structure

In Chapter 2 I begin by asking what exactly makes a digital game Christian, ultimately concluding that there is no established answer. Hence, I create my own definition of Christian digital games, based on the presence of identifiable Christian ideology as defined by long-established religious institutions. With this definition, I explore existing research on the topic and find that existing studies largely neglect to consider content as a possible reason for the negative reception of Christian digital games. I end the chapter by examining related theories that could help explain the reasons behind players’ critique of informative content.

Chapter 3 explains the methodological framework, how I arrived at it using the theories discussed in Chapter 2, and how I applied it to two Christian digital games. I also explain in further detail why I chose the examples I did, and how they fall under the definition of Christian digital games I defined in the previous chapter. Lastly, I perform a game analysis of *Alum* (Orsie, 2015) and *Captain Bible in Dome of Darkness* (Engelbrite, 1994) in Chapter 4, before concluding my study in Chapter 5.

Background & Literature Overview

2.1 | What Are Christian Digital Games?

What makes something, or even someone, “Christian”? Regardless of the subject of discussion, this question is always likely to spark conflicting views. For instance, Schultze and Woods (2008) noted that fans of U2’s Bono have questioned his Christian status after he swore during an award show. The authors further observed that Christian groups also disagree on what it means for a cultural artefact to be Christian. For example, they mention that many Evangelicals consider media as Christian only if it is made by and for Evangelicals. Others, such as Lawton (2021), MacInnis (2025), or Unthank (2023), may prefer to consider content, authorial intent, or media impact when determining whether literature, music, or film is Christian.

Similarly, games scholar Kevin Schut states that currently there is no consensus on what defines a Christian game (Faith Forms, 2024, 8:38). This becomes apparent when one examines online discussion around the topic. For example, one of the factors that Moon Channel (2023) considers when determining if a digital game is Christian is that it must promote Christian morals. Meanwhile, Hartgrove (2022) considers *Hypnospace Outlaw* (Tholen, 2019) a Christian game primarily because its creator, Jay Tholen, identifies as a Christian¹.

From the examples mentioned so far, it becomes evident that the question of what constitutes something as Christian is a highly contentious and subjective matter. Therefore, before analysing the opinions surrounding them, I needed to establish an operational definition of “Christian digital games”.

¹Although Hartgrove does discuss the game’s content somewhat, he does not deem explicit ideological content as necessary for a digital game to be Christian.

2.1.1 | Existing Definitions

Earlier work by Schut (2013) gives us a good starting point for such a definition. Based on a series of interviews with 17 Christians working in the game industry, he outlined four definitions of “Christian Games”. Explicitly Christian Games “feature Bible stories or passages, very clear presentation of the gospel message, and stories that very openly have a Christian worldview”. As an example, Schut raises *Big Bible Town* (Third Day Games, 2010), a digital game which aims to teach children about Bible stories. Meanwhile, Allegorical Christian Games “have stories that are not necessarily openly Christian but have Christian themes or messages underneath them” (p. 137). Interviewees mentioned no instances of such games, but they cited the *Narnia* series (Lewis, 1950–1956/2000) an example of this style.

Interviewees also raised what Schut terms as Evangelical Christian digital games, which “focus on sharing the gospel with people who aren’t Christians”. (pp. 137–138). However, this is only a hypothetical definition since neither Schut nor his interviewees could cite any examples. Lastly, Christian-friendly games, such as *Bejeweled Deluxe* (Karpalka, 2001/2006) (Newtoy, 2009) and *Words With Friends*, are “clean and safe, without significant violence, adult sexuality, swearing, anti-Christian worldviews, and other things that Christians might find offensive or disturbing” (p. 137).

Schut’s work also gives valuable insight into how the term “Christian Games” is used. For example, he notes that most of the interviewees commonly defined “Christian Games” as either Explicitly Christian Games or Allegorically Christian games. However, only few of them considered Christian-friendly games part of the genre. Although this information proved useful for my study, I was hesitant to reuse these definitions due to Schut’s ambiguous use of the term “Christian”; as I have already mentioned in the beginning of this section (see Section 2.1), individuals may not necessarily agree on what determines something as Christian.

Subsequent work by Schut (2026) acknowledges the subjective application of this term (p. 310), and clarifies his use of the term “Christian”. While there are various groups which could be described as Christian, Schut observes that the Christian media industry in North America is influenced primarily by Evangelicals. He attributes their dominance to their collective focus on proselytism and their eagerness to adopt new media technologies as a means to that end. However, he also remarks that Evangelicals have not always counted for the majority of North American Christians, and that they are still garnering a presence in most other countries. Furthermore, he also

notes that other groups, such as Roman Catholics, have also produced Christian games. Consequently, he specifies that, within the context of Christian digital games, the term “Christian” is often synonymous with “Evangelical”, though this is not always the case.

Within the same study, Schut continued to investigate the ways in which Christians have employed the term “Christian” to describe digital games. He found that, occasionally, Christians have argued that digital games with Christian authorship are Christian games. However, after a brief survey of the types of digital games which Christians have described as Christian, Schut concluded that they typically use the term to disclose the presence of Christian ideology within a digital game. However, Schut does not provide a more detailed, formal definition which I could use for my research.

Around 12 years earlier, Gonzalez (2014) had already shown that the overwhelming majority of Christian digital games had Evangelical associations by compiling a comprehensive list of religious digital games. However, unlike Schut, Gonzales does not opt to define Christian games for her research. Instead, she defines “religious games” to study Evangelical digital games within the broader picture of playful religious software. Using “agential realism” as her ontological frame, Gonzales describes something as “religious” if it stages interactions between human and non-human beings (p. 24), such as angels and demons.

Based on this definition, she excludes games like *Castlevania* (Akamatsu, 1986) from her study, which include typically religious materials to embellish their fictional world. She does this because these games do not depict the non-human others as agents with which borders must be negotiated, but as imaginary entities. Similarly, she disregards games such as *Run, Jesus Run!* (Pedercini, 2010) or *Crucify-me! Jesus* (Chapman, 2000), which utilize religious material derisively, since these negotiate boundaries between human groups. Furthermore, Gonzales limits her study to religious organizations, which she defines as a long-lived alliance of human and non-human entities which jointly determine the borders of humanity.

While this definition is more rigorous than either of Schut’s definitions, my original research question does not concern games associated with religions unrelated to Christianity. Therefore, I could not use it for my research. Nevertheless, her definition of religious organisations proved useful as a source of inspiration for my own definition, which I describe in the following section.

2.1.2 | My Definition

Each of the definitions mentioned in the previous section presents valid ideas about what can qualify a game as “Christian” or “religious”. However, given that the definitions are either incomplete or cover games outside my field of study, I could not reuse them for my research. Therefore, using these existing definitions as a point of departure, I created my own definition of “Christian digital games” (or “Christian games” for short).

Due to the vague nature of the “Christian” label, which I have already discussed in the start of this section (see Section 2.1), a complete definition of Christian games also needs to elucidate its use of the term. During my research, I could not find much insight into how players or developers use the term in the context of Christian games. While I have found blogs by Oliver (2014, 2016) which mention Evangelicals when discussing Christian games, there are also other individuals which do not specify any particular denomination (Hartgrove, 2022; Monkastery, 2018; Moon Channel, 2023)². Meanwhile, related studies either fail to elaborate on their usage (Schut, 2013) or employ it as a catch-all term for various religious groups (Bernauer, 2012; Schut, 2026). Furthermore, within her list of religious games, Gonzalez (2014) seems to use “Christian” as an overarching category for games associated with Christianity.

Therefore, to facilitate discussion of existing research, I defined “Christianity” as a blanket term encompassing a constellation of long-lived groups or institutions that promote their interpretations of Christ’s teachings, such as Evangelicals, Presbyterians, Anglicans, Roman Catholics, Greek Orthodox, and Mormons. Similarly, something (e.g. an ideology or belief) or someone is “Christian” when it is primarily based on, or actively aims to observe the teachings of Jesus Christ as understood by one or more of these communities. Of course, these definitions are by no means authoritative; they only serve to establish a common understanding for discussion.

After establishing a working definition of “Christian”, I proceeded by defining Christian games as a genre. I considered defining Christian games as digital games with Christian authorship as suggested by Hartgrove (2022). However, doing so would also include several games which have no significantly religious content. Take Hartgrove’s example for instance. He argues that through its aesthetically pleasing qualities, artistic excellence, and believable characters, *Hypnospace Outlaw* (Tholen, 2019) reveals Tholen’s

²Nevertheless, it is worth noting that the examples cited within these discussions are Evangelical games.

love for beauty originating from his Christian beliefs. While this philosophy can be connected to Christianity, it is hardly exclusive to it. Therefore, based on its content, players may just as easily consider the game as secular.

Based on the remarks by Unthank (2023) on Christian films, I could have chosen to define Christian games based on authorial intent. After all, many Christian games are created with the intent to educate their players about Christianity (Gonzalez, 2014, p. 60; Schut, 2026, pp. 303, 306), so it would have been simple to define Christian games as digital games created with such a purpose. Nevertheless, players have widely acclaimed games outside this category and rarely label them as preachy, in spite of their Christian content³. Therefore, by doing so I would have excluded games of interest to this study.

Furthermore, I explored the possibility of defining Christian games based on the impact a game has on its developers and players, but this was difficult to measure for any given game. Hence, though MacInnis (2025) describes Christian music as music which makes its performers and listeners more willing to love their God and neighbour, I shall not be imitating such efforts for digital games.

Given that I was investigating players' perceptions of Christian digital games, I based my definition on the most common uses of the term, which relate to Christian ideology (Schut, 2026). Other elements, such as biblical stories, Bible quotes, Christian themes and messages, which Schut (2013) outlines in his definitions of Explicitly Christian games and Allegorical Christian games, could be said to be manifestations of such a worldview. Additionally, Gonzalez (2014) remarks that many Evangelical games betray a theology of spiritual warfare prevalent among Evangelicals in the 1980s and 90s, even if ideology is not a prerequisite in her definition of religious games.

Therefore, for this study, “Christian games” are digital games with an underlying Christian worldview that presents itself through legible signifiers. That is, the game contains elements which players can trace to Christian ideology with relative ease.

Obvious examples of such signifiers include adaptations of Bible stories and the

³Throughout my research I found four such games: *That Dragon, Cancer* (Numinous Games, 2016a), *In His Time* (yona, 2023), *and Roger* (yona, 2025), and *Dropsy* (Tholen, 2015). At the time of writing, all four have Steam pages with a rating of over 80% (Numinous Games, 2016b; TearyHand Studio, 2023, 2025; Tendershoot, 2015).

inclusion of Bible quotes, such as in *Super 3-D Noah's Ark* (Wisdom Tree, 1994/2014). Other Christian games indicate their Christian status through their treatment of their scripted narrative's⁴ themes. Consider *That Dragon, Cancer* (Numinous Games, 2016a) themes for example. Its scripted narrative tackles the loss of the developers' son through the lens of their Christian faith, making their spirituality explicit in the process.

Alternatively, scripted narratives in Christian games can feature thinly veiled Christian allegories. The developers of *Alum* (Orsie, 2015), describe it as “a sort of Christian Allegory along the lines of Pilgrims [sic] Progress or The Lion, the Witch, and the Wardrobe” (Crashable Studios, 2015). Some players recognised this, calling *Alum* a Christian game, often citing, or implying, its narrative as their primary reason⁵. One player specifies that they classify it as a Christian game because the game's scripted narrative develops a loving relationship between the titular player character, “Alum”, and a deity called the “Unfeigned Altruist”, while also pitting Alum in a fight against dark forces⁶ (thomascanarias, 2016). Even if players do not notice the parallels to Christianity while playing, the game's ending makes one parallel explicit when it calls Jesus Christ “the true and living Unfeigned Altruist”.

For the most part, *Alum* attempts to be more covert than *Super 3-D Noah's Ark* (Wisdom Tree, 1994/2014) or *That Dragon, Cancer* (Numinous Games, 2016a) about its ties to Christianity. Nevertheless, all three narrow the range of possible associations such that even players with a cursory knowledge of Christianity can make the connection. The same cannot be said about the example raised by Hartgrove (2022); players may just as easily relate the appreciation towards beauty evident within *Hypnospace Outlaw* (Tholen, 2019) to a non-religious worldview.

Since my definition requires the digital game in question to be aligned with Christian ideology, I did not consider games which draw on Christianity for inspiration. So, despite requiring players to journey through hell and slaughter demon hordes, *Doom* (id Software, 1993) falls outside of the field being studied. The same cannot be said for games which reference Christianity to mock it or its followers. As an example, Gonzalez (2014, p. 120) mentions BoMToons, a Mormon game developer which created multiple digital games poking fun at Mormon scripture and culture. However, the examples brought up by players when criticising Christian games, such as *Left Behind: Eternal*

⁴I use the term “scripted narrative” in the way defined by Calleja (2011). I discuss his Player Involvement Model, along with the definition of this term, in Section 2.3.3.

⁵For examples, see Arkane (2015), hamja (2015) and virotti (2017).

⁶See Chapter 4 for a more detailed analysis of *Alum's* narrative.

Forces (Inspired Media Entertainment, 2006) and *Captain Bible in Dome of Darkness* (Engelbrite, 1994)⁷, tend to be more earnest about their subject matter. Hence, I limited my study to digital games which approach Christianity in a more solemn manner.

2.2 | Related Work

With my area of study established, I am now in a position to discuss related research examining mainstream reception of Christian games. As I will demonstrate shortly, this study aims to address an existing research gap by examining the content of Christian games as a potential cause of players' critiques.

Apart from providing four distinct definitions for Christian games (see Section 2.1.1), Schut (2013) also relays the opinions of the interviewees regarding this genre. Some of the developers interviewed did mention that they consider Christian games as preachy (pp. 136, 139), but Schut does not attempt to learn if there are any reasons behind this verdict.

Throughout my research, I was unable to find another study analysing the opinions surrounding Christian games. Gonzalez (2014) briefly mentions bloggers of unnoticed games mocking Christian games (p. 8), and claims of unoriginality (pp. 143–144), an issue closely related to the one under examination. However, her dissertation mostly avoids discussing the enjoyment derived from Christian games. When reflecting on her own experiences playing Evangelical games, she recalls occasions of bewilderment only to dismiss them. Instead, she asserts that she found Evangelical games to be “wonderful, unforgettably good games” (p. 266). Nevertheless, these moments of discomfort may merit further attention; understanding their cause might help clarify the reasons behind certain player’s dismay, and help future developers to avoid these pitfalls. While it may be tempting to dismiss all criticism as snide remarks, it is beneficial to give an honest consideration to negative feedback. This is doubly true when that feedback comes from one’s intended target audience.

Although neither Bernauer (2012) nor Schut (2026) mention the negative opinions surrounding Christian games, both propose reasons for their lack of success. For one, Bernauer maintains that the lack of mainstream interest in Christian games is, in part, due to the explicit Christian convictions presented within these games. Furthermore, she also blames Christian games' (mostly) young target audience, noting that studies

⁷These examples were mentioned by Hartgrove (2022) and Moon Channel (2023) respectively.

found the average gamer to be around thirty-five years old. Lastly, she presents several issues stemming from a lack of finances when comparing Christian game companies to other studios. These include their inability to publish their games on consoles, the lack of both local and online multiplayer in most of their titles, and the short lifespan of these firms.

Meanwhile, Schut attributes three reasons for the lack of commercial success of Christian games within Evangelical circles. Primarily, he ascribes this predicament to the lack of blockbusters within the Christian games industry; unlike Christian television, for instance, Christian games do not have their own *VeggieTales* (Vischer, 1993–2015) to drive sales. He also notes that “the legacy of moral panics over *Dungeons and Dragons* in the 1980s predisposed many Evangelicals to be skeptical of video games” (p. 302). Additionally, he cites an argument by Moon Channel (2023) regarding the Protestant work ethic within America, which conflicts with thriftless, unproductive play. However, Schut admits that Evangelical’s receptiveness towards consumerism discredits this explanation somewhat.

Although all of these reasons may indeed contribute to the unpopularity of Christian games, most of them are factors external to the games’ development process. Bernauer offers actionable suggestions for some of the issues raised, such as targeting older age demographics and making Christian content more implicit. However, most of the reasons given by both researchers are difficult or even impossible for Christian game developers to control. Furthermore, both of them also fail to acknowledge the main reason why many players have decried Christian games in the first place — the games’ content.

Hence, in Chapter 4 I examine two Christian games in the hopes of better understanding what causes certain players to view Christian games as preachy. In the following section, I shall now look at some existing theories which could help explain didacticism in Christian games.

2.3 | Applicable Theories

2.3.1 | Warrant Reduction Assumption

In his article, Repp (2012) describes what he calls the “warrant reduction assumption”. He offers this as an explanation of why literary works, primarily those outside academic contexts, may be considered didactic. In his explanation, he makes two assumptions clear. Firstly, he presupposes that authors can convey their accounts to readers without

necessarily inserting themselves as narrators or characters within the text. Secondly, he presumes that one's writing may convey aspects of their intellectual character. Inspired, by Aristotle's model of moral nature, he proposes that noetic vice can be thought of as gradually ingrained dispositions, which hinder one's enlightenment.

Repp proposes two definitions to explain his theory. "Testimonial beliefs" describe the convictions formed from someone else's accounts, whereas the "warrant" describes the premise on which one believes a source to be trustworthy. He argues that, when authors are overly overt, readers may be given reason to believe that the author might possess some intellectual vice such as zealotry, prejudice, or arrogance. As a result, their warrant for the writer's testimonial beliefs are reduced, since they believe that information being presented is compromised. He likens this phenomenon to when someone is said to "protest too much". In other words, when they argue a point so frequently or emphatically that they raise one's suspicion on the truth of their statements.

Though Repp suggests this theory primarily in relation to literary works, one can see through examples that it also can also apply for Christian games. Take the review by Arkane (2015) for *Alum* (Orsie, 2015), a Christian game which I will be analysing in more detail in Chapter 4. He pans the game for its heavy-handedness, which he blames on the dogmatism of the game's developers. Though he does not call the game "didactic", he still expresses a reasoning very similar to that given by Repp:

I hope the team that worked on this will expand a little bit, bring in some people with different perspectives. Maybe have someone there whose only job is to say, "Hey, that story element you just wrote? Maybe we should find a more subtle approach to implementing it." I'm not saying, "Don't make a religious game." I'm saying don't get caught in an echo chamber of religious ideas and lose sight of the 'game' aspects of it. (para. 5)

The review stands as the most highly rated on the game's Steam page, with 189 users having marked it is helpful as of the time of writing. Though not all of them might share the exact same opinion of Arkane, it is reasonable to assume that his points resonated with some of them. Meanwhile Hartgrove (2022) calls *Left Behind: Eternal Forces* (Inspired Media Entertainment, 2006) "propaganda" (para. 13) due to its promotion of views associated with conservative American Christians and creationists. Censorious Idler (2018) produces very similar critiques about fundamentalism in *Captain Bible in Dome of Darkness*, the other game under analysis in Chapter 4, deeming it "unabashedly

preachy” (A Third Way section, para. 8). Repp considers the terms “propagandistic” and “preachy” to be closely related to “didactic”, when it is used in its negative sense.

Perhaps this theory may help explain some of the negative opinions mentioned in the introduction (see Chapter 1), yet it still leaves others unanswered. For instance, it still does not explain why heavy-handed edification might be considered to be a hindrance to engagement during play (Moon Channel, 2023). We can see this point being also expressed within Arkane’s review, when he notes that the game’s forceful mode of instruction “consumed the mechanics” (para. 4) as the scripted narrative progressed. The warrant reduction assumption also fails to address why players like Adam complain that scripted narratives in Christian games present ideas to players outright (Games and Groceries Podcast, 2020).

While defending his theory against alternate views, he dismisses the idea that didacticism could be viewed negatively because, by pushing a particular reading, it ruins the pleasure of noting how many alternate interpretations one can derive from a work. He rejects this view on the grounds that critics often debate on the intended reading often advancing their own, singular, interpretation. He also contends that didacticism does not necessarily limit readers to a single interpretation, since he believes the issue stems from *how* the message is conveyed, rather than *how many*.

I do concede to Repp’s reasons for rejecting this argument. Nonetheless, as I demonstrate later in Section 2.3.4, he does not completely dismiss the role of interpretation in cases where audiences decry instruction. The next section explores this further through a separate investigation.

2.3.2 | Aesthetic Agency

Instead of investigating “didacticism” and its negative repercussions on intellectual value, King (2017) examines the aesthetic value of subtlety in art and beyond. Specifically, he examines why subtlety is desirable in cases where it is. He does not propose that subtlety is *always* valuable; in some contexts, such as children’s books or dance music, he notes that straightforwardness might be preferred to subtlety. Conversely, what might be considered heavy-handed in one context, might be regarded as bold or direct in other cases.

To understand what makes subtlety valuable in certain occasions, he begins by examining what makes heavy-handedness undesirable in others. Though heavy-handed

art might offend its audience, King does not consider this as a reasonable attribution for the source of its unpleasantness. Similarly, he discredits intentionality as an explanation, since audiences might feel insulted even if the artist did not mean to offend. This statement makes more sense in context, since he brings it into consideration to disregard the notion that subtlety is good because it demonstrates intentionality, and thus the artist's skill.

In contrast to account rejected by Repp (2012), King does not propose that the problem with heavy-handedness might be that it restrict us to a single interpretation *per se*. Rather, he introduces the "show-don't-tell" convention to demonstrate that art is considered heavy-handed when it limits one's freedom to interpret a work (i.e., their aesthetic agency). As King puts it, "[heavy-handedness] clearly manipulates its audience and in doing so, forces them into a passive role" (p. 126). Conversely, subtlety is valuable in cases where it promotes active engagement.

King affirms that audiences can actively engagement with art even when the works in question are not typically considered as interactive. After all, aesthetic appreciation of art may still require one to focus their attention towards it, attempt to become more receptive to its contents, and form their own reading. That being said, active engagement does not necessarily entail conscious or deliberate engagement. He recognises, for example, that engaging with a reference to *Middlemarch* (Eliot, 1871–1872/2008) in the song *How Soon is Now?* (The Smiths, 1985), and understanding how it applies to the song's themes requires mindful reflection. However, readers of *Pride and Prejudice* (Austen, 1813/2002) might respond to Elizabeth Bennet's sudden attraction to Mr. Darcy by recognising it as being financially-driven, even if they do not realise what drove them to that conclusion in the first place.

King extends his account beyond the visual arts, literature, and music, stating that his explanation can also apply to digital games, food, architecture, and even natural beauty. In particular, he notes the following for digital games:

In fact, as an interactive medium, video games emphasize the difference that subtlety can make to the degree of one's engagement. Subtlety makes a video game more realistic and immersive, and encourages players to explore different paths, strategies, and so on. (p. 135)

Indeed, his account does help explain some instances where players complain that

a digital game offers excessive assistance. Take the complaints surrounding the use of yellow paint in triple-A titles. Though such markers might aid more unskilled players in navigating unfamiliar terrain, they may also discourage attentiveness. Therefore, players who might enjoy exploration, may feel disappointment when the game does not allow them to exert their agency in this way. They could even feel insulted that the game is doubting their navigational abilities.

That being said, it still fails to explain other cases where instruction might hinder player engagement due to the manner in which it is included in the digital game. For example, *Bible Adventures Wisdom Tree* (1991) allows players to play through several two-dimensional platforming stages as different biblical figures. Noah's stages feature stone tablets which players can collect using the in-game avatar to restore some health. Unlike more conventional health items, which do nothing else except increasing health, the stone tablets interrupt gameplay with a full-screen close up of the slab and the verse of scripture engraved upon it.

King's account gives us very little clarification on how this element could hinder engagement. One could argue that this breaks the player's involvement with more potentially absorbing parts of the game (e.g., moving, exploring the level, and collecting animals). However, none of this account fits within the explanation provided by King. This lack of insight is caused by the broad scope of his theory, which fails to account for the unique modes of engagement in digital games. In fact, Calleja (2011, Chapter 2) notes a similar difficulty when analysing theories related to immersion.

Therefore, neither of the reasons given by Repp (2012) and King will be able to explain why some players think that educative elements in Christian games can jeopardise engagement (Arkane, 2015; Moon Channel, 2023). In the next section, I will provide a model which could help account for the unique modes of engagement in certain game titles.

2.3.3 | Player Involvement Model

The Player Involvement Model by Calleja (2011) provides a detailed and flexible framework to understand the engaging and immersive affordances within digital games set in virtual environments (i.e., game environments).

In his model, Calleja distinguishes "micro-engagement" from "macro-engagement". The former relates to engagement experienced as the player interacts with a digital

game. Meanwhile, the latter describes engagement outside of gameplay which draws players to begin playing a digital game and return to it later. His model pinpoints different dimensions of engagement, each of which can be analysed in the macro and micro scales. Furthermore, the different dimensions can be combined, such that the players experiences each of the fused dimensions differently.

The Player Involvement Model outlines six types of engagement (i.e., involvement): kinaesthetic, spatial, shared, narrative, affective and ludic. Kinaesthetic involvement concerns the control of the avatar or game pieces. It accounts for the process which players undertake when familiarising themselves with the controls, starting from unfamiliarity and leading to mastery. Meanwhile, manipulation, exploration, and navigation of the virtual environment is covered by the spatial dimension. Shared engagement relates to the player's awareness of, and interactions with, both programmed and human agents. These interactions include collaboration, confrontation, or cohabitation.

Gordon categorises engagement with a digital game's pre-scripted story elements and narratives arising from gameplay in the narrative dimension. He terms the former pre-determined elements as "scripted narrative", and names the latter form of experiential narrative as "alterbiography". These two are not mutually exclusive since scripted narrative pertaining to the player's avatar or game pieces may become part of their alterbiography. Affective involvement describes emotional states triggered by the game, either due to the designer's intentional game design or the player's understanding of the game. Finally, players experience ludic involvement when they engage with choices and their outcomes in the pursuit of game-established goals, personal objectives, or impulsive decisions.

It is worth noting that not all dimensions may be equally relevant to all games. For instance, Gordon observes that *Pong* (Alcorn, 1972) does not give as many affordances for spatial involvement as *Half-Life 2* (Valve, 2004). Gradually, as the player familiarises themselves with a game, they will internalise the different dimensions, thus no longer requiring their conscious attention. Providing the game permits for kinaesthetic and spatial involvement through an avatar, in some cases this can lead to an intensified blend of the different dimensions which Calleja calls "incorporation". He proposes this term as a replacement for "immersion", which he argues is often used to apply to different concepts. That being said, I will not be using this proposed metaphor, since analysing engagement alone be sufficient for this investigation.

Compared to the explanation by King (2017), the Player Involvement Model pro-

vides a far more in-depth framework for reasoning about involving affordances in digital games. More pertinent to this study, it also allows us to better observe how instructive elements within a game might limit such affordances. Consider the example I brought up in Section 2.3.2 regarding *Bible Adventures* (Wisdom Tree, 1991). We can now note how the stone tablets in Noah's levels interrupt kinaesthetic and spatial involvement by temporarily obstructing the player's view of the virtual environment and halting their movement within it.

The Player Involvement Model also gives us further insight into the bright markers, such as yellow paint, used in some triple-A titles, which I have also mentioned in Section 2.3.2. Calleja (2011, pp. 75–77) remarks that navigating a virtual environment in pursuit of some goal can be made all the more engaging if the play knows that they could get lost in the process. Consequently, removing that possibility by providing players with clear markers also limits involvement in the manner just described.

Admittedly, Calleja's model does have some limitations. Even though formal game elements shape player engagement, ultimately, involvement is subject to player subjectivity. Therefore, his model can give a referential frame for understanding player experience within certain game environment. Nonetheless, it is not a silver bullet which allows one to predict how players will experience gameplay. At best, without player feedback, it can only allow us to make an educated guess.

2.3.4 | Compatibility of Individual Theories

After reviewing each of these theories by Repp (2012), King (2017) and Calleja (2011), one might wonder if they are indeed consistent with one another. Perhaps, one could even question whether my proposition which argues that instructive elements could undermine engagement and how it relates to the theories by Repp and King.

In the first respect, one of the arguments Repp employs in defence of his explanation, could seem particularly concerning. Essentially, he highlights that the reason why literature is deemed didactic cannot be related to a flawed aesthetic sensibility. Hence, it might seem that Repp is dismissing aesthetic accounts like the one by King. However, here Repp (2012) uses "aesthetic" in its more classical sense, related to immediate perception. This is most evident when he dismisses the possibility of overtness being an aesthetic feature in literature (p. 282). However, he does not exclude the possibility of an aesthetic account tied to its more modern, subjective meaning. The latter is what King seems to employ given that he considers the possibility of heavy-handedness causing

offence.

Nevertheless, one might still argue against using the two explanations simultaneously given that Repp excludes the possibility of overtness as an explanation for didacticism. Repp reasons that, if overtness, an aesthetic quality closely tied to didacticism, is the reason why critics deemed certain literature didactic, then all forms of unsubtle instruction should be criticised. As an example, he proposes *Middlemarch*, in which Eliot (1871–1872/2008), in the form of an omniscient narrator, repeatedly interjects the narrative to offer his views on the characters and their actions. Repp notes that *Middlemarch* is, without a doubt, explicitly instructive and should thus be considered didactic. Yet, James (1873/2002), in his review of the novel protests that “Fielding was didactic — the author of *Middlemarch* is really philosophic” (para. 5).

At this stage is important that we make a distinction: though both Repp and King try to examine in what way overtness can be a flaw, neither of them try to argue that it is inherently bad. In Section 2.3.2, I have already stressed King’s observation that subtlety, and overtness by consequence, are not always faults. Therefore, it makes sense to think of the two theories as complementary views on why a lack of subtlety can be problematic.

Indeed, Repp (2012) himself seem to imply that heavy-handed instruction may limit interpretative freedom. He observes that “[a]n author who tells her readers too explicitly what lessons to draw from her story, *as if the reader is too obtuse to draw the lesson for himself* [emphasis added], may also come across as intellectually arrogant or condescending” (p. 273). Granted, King (2017) claims that “it is not the audience’s intelligence that is underestimated, it is the audience’s agency” (p. 127). However, given that King himself focuses on cognitive actions as a form of active engagement, I think it is plausible that making such acts redundant could be viewed as an implication against the audience’s mental faculties.

The theory by Repp (2012) is also compatible with my view, since he admits that didacticism may detract from non-cognitive pleasures other than noting the different interpretations that a single text can bring (pp. 272, 284). Admittedly, Calleja (2011, pp. 51–53) does reject tying digital games to prescriptive assumptions of “fun” with good reason. First, this ignores the vast range of emotional states digital games can make us feel. Secondly, amusement can apply to a broad range of experiences which vary from person to person, and is thus too broad of a concept to use for analysis. Regardless, Repp’s account does not exclude that didacticism could somehow obstruct

engagement. Therefore, my framework (see Chapter 3) will examine affordances for engagement rather than delight.

Ignoring King's claim that digital games and narrative art are similar in how they facilitate involvement, his views are also congruent both with the Player Involvement Model and my explanation. King's explanation only relates to instruction when it is unsubtle, and more crucially, this explanation does not exclude a reduction in the dimensions of engagement outlined by Calleja. Consider the yellow paint example once more. If this time a developer uses bright magenta paint to guide player across a lush jungle terrain, then the player could also deem it to be garish. Therefore, in this example, the magenta paint might not only require less attention out of the player to navigate, thereby affording less spatial involvement, but it could also make the environment less desirable to inhabit for some players, reducing affective involvement.

Furthermore, both Calleja and King concede that player might not be aware of their own engagement. Indeed, Calleja's model requires the player to internalize their engagement to experience incorporation. For convenience, I will be using his terminology of "engagement" or "involvement" in the following chapters, and not "active engagement" as King does.

2.4 | Summary

Methodology

Based on the aforementioned theories by Repp (2012), King (2017), and Calleja (2011), I created my own theoretical framework which gives two compatible explanations for why players might criticise overt instruction in digital games, whether they are Christian or not:

- A The game is overly instructive such that players suspect that the knowledge or values presented by the designer are subject to intellectual blindspots.**
- B The game integrates informative elements in ways that hinder player engagement.**

Based on the evidence I provided in Section 2.3.1, I reasoned that the Warrant Reduction Hypothesis could also be applied to digital games, leading me to write account A. Meanwhile, account B is a combination of the observations which King and I made for digital games. In other words, heavy-handed instruction, and the ways in which digital games deliver instruction more broadly, can both restrict the engagement one can derive from a game. I analyse the latter possibility through the lens of the Player Involvement Model (see Section 2.3.3).

One important detail that I would like to mention is that the reasons listed above can contribute to a negative experience of instructional elements *simultaneously*. As I will demonstrate in Section 4.1.2, players have panned the scripted narrative in *Alum* (Orsie, 2015) not only because they suspected that Orsie might be prone to zealotry and prejudice; they also find fault the game's overtness in itself, with one player calling the scripted narrative "insultingly obvious in its Christian intent" (Speedkillsuk, 2017, para. 1).

Using the above framework, I performed a game analysis of two Christian games to understand how their formal elements contribute to player's opinions. While I could have included further examples to help substantiate my claims, I would have run the risk of having to analyse them in a very superficial manner in doing so. Therefore, to keep the analysis insightful, I opted for a smaller sample of games.

For my first case study, I chose *Alum* (Orsie, 2015), primarily due to the substantial of reviews decrying the game for the unsubtle delivery of its themes. I explore these reviews more thoroughly in Section 4.1.2, but, for reference, I have already discussed the review by Arkane (2015) in Section 2.3.1. There are also further examples such as the reviews by adam1224 (2017), baxted (2015), stranger1982 (2015), and virotti (2017). Furthermore, I have already shown in Section 2.1.2 that the game complies with my own definition of Christian games.

I chose *Captain Bible in Dome of Darkness* (Engelbrite, 1994), or *Captain Bible*, as I will refer to it from now on, as my second case study. Like *Alum*, it also fits my working definition of Christian games, given its clear Biblical theming and Christian moral lessons, which it delivers through interactive theological arguments against robotic enemies and deceived citizen Non-Playable Characters (NPCs). Furthermore, *Captain Bible* is one of the few Christian games I am aware of which integrates moral instruction with game-play in a comprehensive manner.

To my knowledge, many Christian edutainment games are either “digitised Sunday School exercises” (Gonzalez, 2014, p. 60) such as virtual quizzes, crossword puzzles, jigsaw puzzles, word jumbles, colouring books and hangman (p. 119) or rehash existing genre conventions with the addition of Christian theming or, in the case of *The Bible Game*, multiple-choice questions relating to Christianity (Bogost, 2007, pp. 288–289). Other games may also include Bible quotes (e.g., *Bible Adventures* (Wisdom Tree, 1991), *Catechumen* (Bagley, 2000), *Left Behind: Eternal Forces* (Inspired Media Entertainment, 2006)).

Players of *Captain Bible* also seem to view the game as unique in this way. While discussing the game, annk526 (2024, Shucks, Why Do You Want Me To Play This? section, para. 5) observes that “there are not a lot of Christian Video Games [sic], and most of the ones people know are reskins or rehashes of other ideas with a ‘choose the right answer’ style multiple choice that feels tacked on”. Furthermore, Censorious Idler (2018, para. 1) praises the game as “a successful synthesis of the ludic (in Huizinga’s sense) and didactic principles necessitated by the video game form and its Evangelical heritage”, and

mentions that few other Christian games do the same (In Retrospect section). Therefore, if the educational game design in *Captain Bible* is somehow limiting player engagement, it should be rather obvious; more so than the example I gave using *Bible Adventures* in Sections 2.3.2 and 2.3.3.

As I have already noted in Section 2.3.3, player involvement is influenced not only by game design but also by player subjectivity. Therefore, to prevent my analysis from becoming too subjective, I will supplement my analysis with player reviews taken from blogs and online platforms such as Steam and YouTube. Of these reviews, I will only be considering those written or spoken in English. I do this not only because of my familiarity with the language, but also to keep my research accessible.

3.1 | Summary

Analysis & Discussion

4.1 | Alum

4.1.1 | Gameplay and Narrative Overview

Alum (Orsie, 2015) is a point-and-click adventure game heavily inspired by older titles developed by LucasArts and Sierra Entertainment. Like those games, *Alum* features an overarching scripted narrative which players must progress by interacting with the environment. They can do so through an avatar capable of performing different actions (i.e., “verbs”) and an inventory, which they can use to store and combine items. Occasionally, *Alum* adds some variety by requiring the player to complete action sequences, such as a sniper mini-game. Furthermore, the game also allows the player to diverge from the main sequence of scripted events on three occasions. However, in each case, doing so triggers a brief narrative sequence that leads directly to a game over screen.

The game’s storyline revolves around Alum Descry, a resident of Kosmos City in the land of Tide. Just like many of the city’s inhabitants, Alum’s wife, Esther, is afflicted by a disease known as “the Vague”, which causes her to perceive life as meaningless and withdraw from others, remaining mostly silent. Alum makes it his goal to find a cure, and in the process discovers the rushlight — a pendant filled with a mysterious cyan liquid. Drinking from a rushlight allows one to speak with the Unfeigned Altruist, a deity with the power to heal the Vague.

In Chapter 2, Alum almost succumbs to the Vague himself. After drinking from a rushlight, the Altruist tells Alum to share it with everyone he meets so they, too, can be cured. However, Mr Glymm, the Mayor of Kosmos, impedes Alum’s attempts to save Esther by collaborating with an evil spirit called “the Invidious Umbra”. At the beginning, the game depicts Glymm as a great leader who does his best to protect his citizens from the many dangers that threaten their lives. We are told that he commissioned a

giant heating device called a “heat pillar” to protect the citizens from the cold temperatures of Tide. Furthermore, he also deploys a fleet of armed androids called “E-bots” to protect the residents from being ambushed by demonic spirits called “lurids”.

Later, the game reveals that in fact the heat pillars and E-bots are both ploys to keep the citizens of Kosmos from leaving the city. In fact, the temperatures outside the city are not as cold as Glymm claims. Furthermore, the Umbra, who holds dominion over the other lurids, stages lurid attacks to convince residents that the E-bots, and Glymm by extension, are protecting the city effectively. Therefore, not only do they see Glymm as a capable leader, but they also believe that they are safer in Kosmos. In this manner, Glymm and the Umbra prevent the inhabitants from discovering rushlights outside the city borders. Additionally, they actively hunt down anyone who tries to smuggle rushlights into the city. In this manner, both get to preserve their own positions of power and keep the Unfeigned Altruist out of Kosmos.

Throughout the course of the game, Alum allies himself with a resistance group called “the Rogations” which also aim to bring rushlights to Kosmos. By the end of the game’s narrative arc, Alum manages to storm the city with the help of an ancient race of rushlight bearers inhabiting “Outer Tide”, that is, the lands beyond the mountain range encircling Kosmos. In the city, he rescues the Rogations from capture, and with their help, confronts Mr Glymm and saves the city from the Umbra’s dark influence.

Before moving on with the analysis, I should also mention that though players complete most of the game as Alum, they can occasionally control members of the Rogations, such as Dashu, the group’s leader, or Jacob. There is much more that could be said about the scripted narrative in *Alum* (Orsie, 2015). Nevertheless, I will discuss any further details as they become relevant to the discussion at hand.

4.1.2 | Key Observations

Some of the scripted narrative in Alum might easily give the impression that (Orsie, 2015) is a religious partisan. Consider Chapter 5, where Dashu attempts to blow up one of the heat pillars with explosives at the behest of the Unfeigned Altruist. In-game, players aid in this effort by playing a sniper minigame, where the player must cover Dashu from patrolling E-bots as he plants explosives on the tower. According to the Rogations, doing so would allow the citizens of Kosmos to see Glymm for the liar he is and thus depose him. With him gone, there would be no authority to enforce an embargo on rushlights, opening the city to the influence of the Altruist. Titus, the Rogation’s me-

chanic, also reassures the team that no one should be harmed in the process, since the heat pillar is maintained only by E-bots.

Despite this, the action can be easily interpreted as an act of terrorism, or a feat more befitting a crusade, as it has been by adam1224 (2017, para. 2) and Innuendo Studios (2020, 9:43) respectively. Moreover, this deed is never portrayed as immoral within the scripted narrative. On the contrary, Orsie (2015) seems to have included it to promote the value of obeying God's will. I say this because on other occasions, the scripted narrative punishes Alum for ignoring the Altruist's instructions. For instance, in Chapter 4, when Alum disobeys the Altruist's wishes to lead the Rogations to Outer Tide and attempts to rescue Esther from Glymm's E-bot factory, he fails. In response, Alum abandons the Altruist completely, and thus ends up being deceived and tormented by the Invidious Umbra in Chapter 5.

Therefore, when adam1224 (2017, para. 3) complains about the game promoting a lack of critical thought, or when Innuendo Studios (2020, 9:43) opines that Alum seems to be overly eager for religious war, what they are really complaining about is the intellectual blind spot that the scripted narrative seems to suggest. For these players, incidents like the one in Chapter 5 argue so strongly for divine obedience that they conclude that Orsie (2015) must be dogmatic.

These are not the only events that have led players to suspect that Orsie (2015) might be a zealot. Innuendo Studios (2020, 9:50) also argues that the game excuses murder in Chapter 7. During Alum's final showdown against Glymm, players can participate in an action sequence. If they are successful, they are rewarded with a scripted sequence in which Alum defenestrates Glymm. Granted, the game later reveals that he did not die from Alum's initial attempt. It only shows us his death after a cutscene where Alum refuses to follow the Altruist's instruction to let Esther drink from his rushlight, thereby implying that Alum's defiance caused Glymm's death.

Hence, it could be argued that this action was not intended by the Altruist, or even Alum, as evidenced by his shock when he realises that he killed Glymm. In this way, the scripted narrative could still be said to disapprove of his actions. However, for Innuendo Studios (2020), Alum's homicide points to a broader pattern which justifies brutality in the name of God, along with the other aggressive acts Alum and the Rogations commit (e.g., the murder of an ice giant, breaking into the Kosmos City wall using explosives, etc.).

Players have also made similar remarks regarding another event within Chapter 4, which might suggest that Orsie (2015) is also prone to prejudice. While in Slip Town, Alum is asked to locate one of the townsmen's sons, which he insists was kidnapped by a member of the Chagrin order. To rescue the child, players must knock a Chagrin unconscious to steal their robes so that Alum can infiltrate their headquarters. As Innuendo Studios (2020, 9:27) notes, at this stage Alum has no proof indicating the Chagrin as the culprits in a kidnapping. Regardless, Alum rationalises his violent action while speaking to the unconscious cult member: "I'm sorry, buddy, I need this robe. Besides, if you're stealing children, you needed that." (Orsie, 2015).

Admittedly, unlike in the previous case, Alum is not acting under the Altruist's orders when he does this. Nevertheless, Innuendo Studios (2020, 9:27) still criticises this moment for the religious violence it portrays. On the other hand, virotti (2017, Consecration, para. 3) interprets the inclusion of the Chagrin as an insinuation against Muslims being devil worshippers. He says this because parts of the scripted narrative reveal that the Chagrin are actually worshipping the Invidious Umbra, the in-universe equivalent of Satan. That being said, the only element in the scripted narrative that seems to lead players towards this interpretation is that they speak a different language from that of the other characters.

In Chapter 2, the game begins to allude to Christianity in ways that become more overt as the central plot advances. When Alum first meets with the Altruist, he tells Alum that the Vague is a void in one's heart that everyone is born with, and that can only be healed by him. If they do not drink from the rushlight, then the Vague will consume them until they die. There, according to the Altruist, "it will keep them forever". Later on, in Chapter 3, speaking to Elzy, one of the Rogation members, prompts a line of dialogue in which she mentions that "the Unfeigned Altruist works in mysterious ways". This of course, is a modified version of the cliché phrase "God works in mysterious ways". Even later, in Chapter 4, Alum must retrieve the Fork of Babel, described as an ancient relic from when the Altruist caused different groups to begin speaking different languages.

Following the account by King (2017), one would expect some players to complain that the narrative arc became unbearably overt after the second chapter. While this seems to be the case, I cannot rule out the possibility that players might be complaining about the game's lack of subtlety for entirely different causes. For example, kevintheradioguy (2018, para. 4) considers the first two Chapters of the game to be acceptably subtle. However, instead of noting the lack of interpretative freedom thereafter, he

proceeds to complain that the character's motivations were not sufficiently complex. Though King notes that subtlety and complexity can both require audiences to pay more attention, he ultimately distinguishes the two as separate concepts.

Meanwhile, adam1224 (2017) claims that the scripted narrative's Christian allusions became obvious when it directly referenced the Tower of Babel. Nevertheless, his review seems more concerned about the lack of critical thinking that he perceives in the game's scripted narrative. Thus, they may consider the overtness of the scripted narrative objectionable because it reveals the author's dogmatism.

Snake (2016) opines that after "[a]n hour and a half... I was no longer playing Alum, but rather 'Jesus, Your Lord and Savior - the Bejesusing'" (para. 1). Given that the first chapter takes about an hour to complete, it would seem that Snake is likely indicating the second Chapter as the point where his experience with the game took a turn for the worse. Later on, he also mentions that playing the game made them feel like they were being brainwashed (para. 2). As such, it could be that they, like adam1224 (2017), were displeased with the scripted narrative's apparent zealotry rather than its stripping them of their aesthetic agency.

The review by Speedkillsuk (2017) might seem more promising in that they call the scripted narrative "a patronising attempt at emotional manipulation" (para. 1) that is "insultingly obvious in its Christian intent" (para. 1). In the case of the first remark, it is interesting to note that, according to King (2017, footnote 13), emotional appeal can help distract from the lack of aesthetic agency caused by heavy-handed instruction. Lastly, Speedkillsuk also observes that they stopped enjoying the game after an hour or so. Thus, it could be that Speedkillsuk lost their interest in the game after starting the second Chapter.

Yet, part of the offence and condescension perceived by Speedkillsuk (2017) seems to stem from their belief that the game portrays the converted characters as inherently better than others. Hence, their faults with the scripted narrative could be, at least in part, because of perceived arrogance. Moreover, they admit that they would have found the game less insulting if it had been less covert about its Christian status in its marketing ¹. Perhaps, then, aesthetic agency might not be the only cause of their outrage.

¹In Section 2.1.2, I have mentioned the developers' comparison of their game to other allegorical Christian narratives, which is present on its Steam store page. Other, more visible parts of the game's Steam page do not seem to make the game's Christian inspirations clear (Crashable Studios, 2015).

All in all, it seems plausible that later chapters in *Alum* (Orsie, 2015) could have reduced these players' aesthetic agency. Nonetheless, the reasons they explicitly mention seem more concerned with the noetic vice or other forms of engagement. Therefore, I could not conclusively prove that the players found the game's overtness concerning in this way.

4.2 | Captain Bible in Dome of Darkness

4.2.1 | Gameplay and Narrative Overview

Captain Bible (Engelbrite, 1994) is a game made for the Microsoft Disk Operating System, which was marketed for players aged seven and up. It features a linear scripted narrative about Captain Bible, a member of the Bible Corps. He is tasked with saving a city shrouded in a dome of darkness, which makes citizens more prone to deception. To do so, he must find seven individuals who can help him pilot the "Unibot", a giant robot that serves as the city's last line of defence. Using the Unibot, Captain Bible must destroy the seven dome-generating towers within the city to save all of the inhabitants and restore order.

Players progress the scripted narrative through a relatively stable routine of actions (i.e., a core gameplay loop). Players must search a level comprised of interconnected corridors and rooms for verses of scripture, which they can obtain from "Scripture Stations" or intercommunications rooms. In turn, through various means, these items allow them to unlock new areas within the map for further exploration. Doing so often involves revisiting previously explored areas. Therefore, a player will have to go back and forth through the same areas multiple times to complete a level.

Eventually, after collecting the relevant Bible quotes, players will be able to complete a scripted dialogue sequence with a NPC, leading to the NPC's repentance. Doing so allows the player to progress to the next level. Between levels, the player must walk through exposed passages, where a small robot zaps Captain Bible, stripping him of all the Bible verses and power-ups on his person. This allows the player to repeat the process for the next level, and the ones after. In total, the player must perform this list of tasks seven times before they can navigate the Unibot through the city and destroy the seven towers.

The game includes multiple types of obstacles which require Bible quotes to progress. Namely, there are the villainous "Cybers", which present Captain Bible with a "Cyber

lie” when confronted. To progress, the player, as Captain Bible, must present a verse that contradicts the Cyber’s statement. For example, when presented with “God wants to kill the sinners before they get a chance to repent.”, the player must object using Ezekiel 18:23: “Do I take any pleasure in the death of the wicked? declares the Sovereign Lord. Rather, am I not pleased when they turn from their ways and live?” (*New International Version Bible*, 1978/2011). If the player selects the correct excerpt, then they must also defeat the Cyber in a brief combat sequence.

Some areas are also locked behind doors which require specific Bible verses to unlock. These “Match to Unlock” segments, as they are called in-game, are very similar to Cyber lies in that the player must still respond to a statement, albeit a more positive one. For instance, Ezekiel 18:23 (*New International Version Bible*, 1978/2011) is also used to respond to the claim that “God doesn’t want to destroy people, but to see them repent and really live.”.

Though they lead nowhere, levels also contain trap rooms which also require the player to have the relevant verse to leave unharmed. These function almost identically to the Cyber lies presented by the Cybers scattered throughout the levels. Unlike Cybers, however, players cannot choose to disengage from trap rooms. Furthermore, after choosing the right verse, players do not need to participate in a battle.

4.2.2 | Key Observations

Before diving into an analysis of the ludic involvement afforded through the core gameplay loop in Captain Bible, we must first cover some theory related to the Player Involvement Model (Calleja, 2011).

At times, digital games may entice players to pursue specific goals to obtain a reward. For instance, by increasing their avatar’s level in *Planetside* (Rogue Planet Games, 2003), players can enhance existing abilities or unlock new ones which facilitate certain objectives or tasks. Other games, such as *Grand Theft Auto IV* (Rockstar North, 2008), reward players with cutscenes after completing in-game “missions” related to the primary plotline (Calleja, 2011, Chapters 7, 9).

Certain rewards can be tied to affective engagement. For example, in more stimulating games, players can be emotionally invested in achieving goals reflecting on their skill. Failing to achieve such a goal can be frustrating if the player believes they are capable of attaining it. By contrast, if the player achieves a goal that they consider valu-

able, they will likely find the experience intrinsically rewarding. Meanwhile, in some cases digital games may provide more soothing, aesthetically pleasing rewards such as beautiful vistas (Calleja, 2011, Chapters 5, 8, 9).

As noted by Calleja (2011), not all players might find such rewards to be desirable. He considers cutscenes as an example: eager to continue playing, some players may skip a cutscene, whereas others might pause to follow the scripted narrative. Regardless, many of these rewards often tie to other dimensions of involvement. For instance, new or enhanced abilities can foster a sense of agency, which Calleja relates to the macro stage of the kinaesthetic dimension. Breath-taking sights not only enable aesthetic engagement, but also spatial involvement, since spatial involvement, as understood by Calleja, can be driven by a desire to make discoveries.

In effect, the cycle of actions required to complete *Captain Bible* (Engelbrite, 1994) is very similar to that required by another genre of games — Metroidvanias. Just like in Metroidvanias, players of *Captain Bible* must backtrack repeatedly to obtain items which allow them to explore new areas of the map and progress the game. Despite requiring repeated traversal of the same areas, a task which players might find tedious in other games, Metroidvanias, such as *Hollow Knight* (Team Cherry, 2017), still manage to make such exploration feel rewarding for some players. Therefore, to better illustrate how *Captain Bible* fails to encourage ludic engagement, I will first consider the affordances for such engagement in *Hollow Knight*.

While playing *Hollow Knight* (Team Cherry, 2017), the game builds the expectation that exploration will lead to rewards that afford further engagement. For instance, by navigating through the game's interconnected map, *Hollow Knight* allows players to find items (e.g., mask shards, charms) that enhance or modify the avatar's attributes and abilities. These items afford further kinaesthetic engagement, since more advantageous stats allow greater resilience against enemies, thus increasing agency and allowing less skilled players to better navigate areas with difficult foes. In turn, this might allow them to explore those areas more thoroughly and make new findings, leading to further spatial and affective involvement.

Additionally, players can unlock abilities that create new movement options. These abilities allow players to make further discoveries by unlocking otherwise inaccessible parts of the map, and they are engaging in their own right; by being given new moves to master, players can deepen their kinaesthetic engagement even further. *Hollow Knight* (Team Cherry, 2017) also rewards exploration by including awe-inspiring areas, which

some players might find soothing. As Calleja (2011, p. 175) notes, the affect caused by such scenes can be intensified if preceded by difficult combat, a quality *Hollow Knight* is well known for. As a matter of fact, user CrazySquare (2019) states the following in a forum thread asking what everyone's favourite area in the game is: "I find this area in Queen's Gardens really cozy and pretty, especially after all the annoying enemies you had to get through to get there" (para. 2).

With these facts in mind, we can now understand why retracing one's steps can be engaging in *Hollow Knight* (Team Cherry, 2017). The map is designed so that the player will almost inevitably encounter obstacles that prevent them from exploring a particular direction. Thus, when the player finally gains an ability that allows him to traverse through such obstacles, those spaces are recontextualised as gateways to further interesting discoveries. If the player has no motivation to explore further, no exciting novelties to anticipate, then further exploration seems pointless.

By contrast, in *Captain Bible* (Engelbrite, 1994), exploration mostly nets the players more biblical knowledge; verses of scripture allow players to collect even more verses, and this goes on until they have all the necessary excerpts to complete a scripted dialogue with one of the game's NPCs. Furthermore, the latter sequences also serve to edify the player about the dangers of greed, new-age practices, and drug abuse among other tendencies. Admittedly, such knowledge can have its own appeal, for example, if one wants to memorise scripture. Nonetheless, it creates no further avenues for involvement in the dimensions of the Player Involvement Model (Calleja, 2011).

The game does provide some novelties within different levels, such as unique obstacles (e.g., ambushing Cybers) and unique modes of transport (e.g., Jump Tunnels, a futuristic hot-air balloon, a flight power-up). The Jump Tunnels, which are used on the first level, also function as an isolated mini-game where the player must help Captain Bible avoid oncoming enemies by directing him left or right. Admittedly, these do afford some kinaesthetic engagement as the player must quickly navigate their avatar to avoid damage. However, these sections are sparse, brief, and very limited in the movement they allow.

Meanwhile, other inclusions such as the hot-air balloon and the flight power-up serve as brief cutscenes between otherwise disconnected sections of the level. Perhaps, these could afford some affective involvement if the game's visuals enamour the player, as is the case for Censorious Idler (2018). Nevertheless, these cutscenes provide very limited opportunities for involvement.

Other elements within *Captain Bible* (Engelbrite, 1994) similarly fail to provide many avenues for engagement. For example, the corridors within a level mix and match different assets in a way that makes them difficult to distinguish. Consequently, it is unlikely that the players will find any view they consider interesting. Additionally, unlike the cutscenes in *Grand Theft Auto IV* (Rockstar North, 2008) mentioned by Calleja (2011, p. 163), the conversion sequences in *Captain Bible* are more focused on conveying moral lessons than they are on presenting intricate characters. This decision is understandable, considering the game's young target demographic and educational aims. That being said, these scripted narratives are unlikely to engage older players unless, for example, they find spiritual value in the morals they convey.

Some Bible verses might allow players to receive power-ups. I have already mentioned the flight power-up, but there are others as well. The Sword of the Spirit and the Shield of Faith aid the player whilst engaging in close-quarters combat against the Cybers. For players like Ace101 (2013), who already find the combat to be trivially easy, this only serves to make the combat even less engaging in the shared dimension. Granted, others like annk526 (2024) might still find some catharsis when the Cyber dies in an explosion, or in a similarly spectacular fashion.

The light power-up allows the players to traverse through dark hallways on a given level. Thus, it serves as another “key” of sorts, which provides no engagement on its own. Lastly, the anti-trap power-up indicates to the player which rooms are traps. Therefore, players who find such rooms to be frustrating (e.g., Censorious Idler (2018, Mechanics section, para. 8)) might find such a reward to be valuable. On the other hand, this might ironically draw attention to the game's already sparse affordances for affective involvement.

Consequently, these facts might make players like TurblesCelbor (2025, The Bad section, para. 3) feel as if there is not much to do in the game except collect verses of scripture. Granted, other players such as Censorious Idler (2018, In Retrospect section, para. 3)) may find the gameplay to be rewarding. Regardless, for some players, the choice to prioritise moral instruction while neglecting ludic engagement leads them to view the former negatively.

Apart from the lack of ludic engagement, the practically unchanging core gameplay loop in *Captain Bible* also seems to inhibit affective involvement. In fact, several players complain about the repetitiveness of the game loop, calling it “uninteresting” (TurblesCelbor, 2025, The Bad section, para. 2), mind-numbing (Ace101, 2013, para. 3)

or “tedious” (annk526, 2024, Gameplay section, para. 1). Calleja (2011, p. 162) mentions that occasionally players might still engage with monotonous tasks in Massive Multi-player Online Games, if the reward for doing so is valuable to the player. Unfortunately, as I have already expressed, Captain Bible offers little engagement in the ludic dimension, making it less likely for players to persist.

Additionally, several other game elements, though unrelated to the game’s instructive mechanisms, also contribute to this sense of boredom. For instance, Cybers within a given level may present players with the same Cyber lie, prompting the player to answer with the same Bible verse (brutalmoose, 2014, 7:44). Ace101 (2013, para. 6) notes how each level is accompanied by the same, short, looping musical track. Meanwhile, annk526 (2024) mentions the “clone-stamped hallways” (Gameplay section, para. 1) within levels, which blend together as the player tries to navigate to their destination.

All these comments notwithstanding, players may still find some formal elements affectively engaging. I have already noted some of these earlier (e.g., the trap rooms and the Cybers’ death animations). Censorious Idler (2018, Aesthetics section) provides us with another example when he praises the game for its bleak, lonely atmosphere.

4.3 | Summary

Conclusions

This study began with a single question: “Why is instruction in Christian games sometimes considered bad?”. To answer this question, I first began by providing my own working definition of the “Christian” genre based on observations from Gonzalez (2014) and Schut (2026). I described something (or someone) as Christian if it (or they) make a significant effort to follow the interpretation of any long-standing group or institution regarding the teachings of Jesus Christ. Then, I defined Christian games as ones with a Christian worldview, that is made evident through accessible signifiers.

This allowed me to look at research related to this definition. However, I soon realised that only Schut (2013) had mentioned issues related to players’ perceptions of instructive elements. Other works either sidestepped such issues entirely (Gonzalez, 2014), or mostly neglected to consider the games’ contents as a potential point of failure (Bernauer, 2012; Schut, 2026).

Therefore, I looked elsewhere for answers and found theories by King (2017) and Repp (2012), each giving accounts of why heavy-handedness and heavy-handed instruction can be considered flaws, respectively; whereas the former proposes that didacticism might be an issue caused by perceived intellectual dishonesty, the latter blames problems concerning overttness on a restriction of aesthetic agency. I also proposed that the manner in which a game delivers instruction can also reduce engagement in the dimensions of the Player Involvement Model (Calleja, 2011).

After confirming that the theories are compatible, I combined them into a single framework. I used it to produce analyses of two Christian games: *Alum* (Orsie, 2015) and *Captain Bible* (Engelbrite, 1994). Through examples, I showed how the scripted narrative in *Alum* (Orsie, 2015) might lead some players to suspect intellectual shortcomings such as dogmatism and prejudice. However, I found it more difficult to show that *Alum* restricts interpretative freedom. Although it might be a possible explanation,

the relevant reviews I found could be explained in other ways. Meanwhile, in *Captain Bible* I observed that its repetitive core gameplay loop, along with other formal elements, limits the affordances for ludic and affective involvement, making the levels feel vacant and dull. Therefore, players could disapprove of the game's attempts to edify.

5.1 | Revisiting the Aims and Objectives

In Section 1.2, I outlined three goals for this research. First, the proposed theory must explain why instruction in Christian games can be considered negatively. Second, the explanation provided through said theory must be clear enough for developers to recognise potential solutions more easily. Thirdly, the issues it uncovers must be actionable.

Generally speaking, the framework proved quite practical in diagnosing the underlying issues in *Alum* (Orsie, 2015) and *Captain Bible* (Engelbrite, 1994). Though I did not manage to make significant findings using the theory by King (2017), the warrant reduction assumption (Repp, 2012) and Player Involvement Model (Calleja, 2011) proved to be quite useful. While I believe they are likely to apply to other digital games with similar issues, whether or not they are Christian, it would be unwise to make generalising statements given the small breadth of examples.

Regardless, for the examples in question, applying the framework helps clarify the issues indicated by players, thus meeting the first objective. Consequently, one might be able to suggest certain courses of action more confidently (i.e., for the examples I considered, it also meets the second aim). For instance, given that *Alum* (Orsie, 2015) seems to appeal to more than just a Christian audience, Orsie could prevent signs of cognitive vice by introducing a non-Christian playtester in his future projects. It is also possible that he could benefit from applying muse-based game design (Khaled, 2012). Not only would it allow him to get early input on his scripted narrative, but it would also require few resources, which might be appealing for an indie team like Crashable Studios.

Likewise, one could perhaps try decreasing the tedium of *Captain Bible* (Engelbrite, 1994) by reducing the number of levels that one has to complete, or by increasing the variety of Cyber-lies and bible verses that can appear within a level. Admittedly, adding assets such as new music and background art may require significant funding, so some solutions might be budget-constrained. Regardless, my goal in describing these potential solutions is not to offer easy-to-implement suggestions guaranteed to work. After

all, that would fall outside of the scope of my project. My point here is that the issues described for *Alum* (Orsie, 2015) and *Captain Bible* are actionable, even if the actions that one can take might be restricted. Therefore, one could say that the third aim of this project has also been met, even if to a limited extent.

5.2 | Critique and Limitations

Using public reviews did facilitate feedback collection, especially since the games are quite niche. However, it is possible that this choice could have introduced some bias in the dataset. For example, using existing reviews might bias my sample towards players or internet personalities who felt more strongly about the game in question. Furthermore, due to its old age, it was difficult to find online reviews for *Captain Bible* (Engelbrite, 1994). Therefore, I may have missed some feedback in this way.

Other types of qualitative data analysis like coding typically allow the theory from their dataset rather than starting with an established theory. However, by starting with existing accounts, I might have skewed my interpretation of the reviews I found. Though I suspect that a qualitative approach would have likely led to similar conclusions to the ones I draw, qualitative methods could still draw more nuanced findings. Finally, because I use the Player Involvement Model (Calleja, 2011), my framework is primarily useful for game environments. It gives less insight, for example, into Christian trivia games such as *Heroes* (Neves, 2021).

5.3 | Future Work

Studying negative experiences of instruction in Christian games has its own value. As I have shown in Section 5.1, such an analysis could help indicate what might remedy the issues in question. Regardless, suggesting a solution is not the same as proving that it works. Therefore, future studies could consider analysing Christian games that have been more positively received despite their Christian themes, such as *In His Time* (yona, 2023), *and Roger* (yona, 2025), and *Dropsy*¹ (Tholen, 2015).

Given that finances might still be a limiting factor for Christian game development (see Section 5.1), it might be valuable to conduct research by design to explore low-cost

¹Tholen, the lead designer and developer of *Dropsy*, has stated that he does not consider it as “a Christian thing” (Sinclair, 2019, para. 5). Nevertheless, the game’s ending features some undeniably Christian themes, and players have discussed its ties to Christianity (Innuendo Studios, 2020; JuneCrashRadio, 2024; Mackerel Phones, 2020).

methods for developing games. For example, one could experiment with using text-based game engines such as Twine. Lastly, one could also use the principle discussed by King (2017) to investigate cases similar to the yellow paint example mentioned in Section 2.3.2, where players complain about excessive assistance in games (i.e., hand-holding).

5.4 | Final Remarks

Many of the critiques I mention throughout the introduction are actually written or said by Christians (Games and Groceries Podcast, 2020; Hartgrove, 2022; Monkastery, 2024; Moon Channel, 2023; Schut, 2013). For these Christian players, the complaints discussed seem to reflect disappointment with the lack of what they perceive as quality titles and with the consequences these games may have for Christianity's reputation as a whole.

It is enough to look at Jay Tholen's comments in which he reports feeling frustrated after looking through games in a Christian game development community (Oliver, 2014, paras. 6–7) or the lament by ScrewAttack (2012, September 12/2024) about how *Captain Bible's* (Engelbrite, 1994) fundamentalism might impact mainstream perception of Christians.

Add to this a dispiriting suggestion similar to that by YouTuber Moon Channel (2023), which proposes that Christian games need to be developed in a non-American context to improve, essentially limiting a large percentage of Christian game production (Schut, 2026, p. 301). Consequently, it can seem that producing acclaimed Christian games is a daunting task, if not a nigh impossible one.

Yet more recent game productions seem to offer some hope, not only for non-American markets but also for U.S. markets. I have already mentioned *Dropsy* by Germany-based American developer Jay Tholen (2015), *That Dragon, Cancer* by American indie team (Numinous Games, 2016a), and even the contributions by Japanese developer yona (2023, 2025). I hope that this study continues to contribute to the view that not only are quality Christian games possible, but that they are far more plausible than we might initially realise.

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